Studio Time = Money

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Abstract

In this talk, I argue that an analysis of how monetary relations define and transform musical practices is essential to an understanding of current directions in contemporary music. I will examine the enduring problem of monetary pressures on musicians and the significance of money for musical production, and consider how the force of monetary relations has shaped on-going debates among musicians about the value of their art. I will also consider how the advent of analogue and digital processes-in both the realms of popular and experimental music---has reinforced the cycles of optimism and pessimism that defines much cultural criticism. At issue will be the role of the recording studio in contemporary music, particularly as a consequence of mass commercial recording, and the social myths and rites that inform and orient current studio practices. Of specific concern will be how musicians use their studio time, who pays for it when they do, and at what cost to themselves and to music. Thus, the overall focus of this presentation is on the social value of contemporary music acts.